



SERIES III — APPLIED PROTOCOLS · REPORT 04

Penguin Dashboard

Legibility as Governance: a shared monthly reading of place, people, and coordination

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This reader edition concentrates the Dashboard as a usable instrument. The broader March 2026 system compilation remains available in the Integrated v17 archive .



Abstract

The Penguin Dashboard is a light governance instrument for groups caring for a place. Once each month, or at another locally appropriate rhythm, a steward circle reads three conditions separately: the condition of land and ecology; the viability of the people carrying the work; and the clarity of governance and collaboration.

The circle uses locally calibrated observations, assigns a working Green, Yellow, or Red reading to each stream, records uncertainty or dissent, and chooses no more than three next actions. The colours are not scores. They are shared judgments that help a group act before ecological harm, human exhaustion, or governance confusion becomes normalised.

Fifteen starter observations and a one-page snapshot make the practice accessible. Supporting measurements, testimony, photographs, and records remain in an evidence trail. No green stream compensates for a red one, and no algorithm or AI system makes the final judgment.

About Planetary Guardians

Planetary Guardians develops open, place-bound methods for ecological stewardship, shared observation, and accountable governance. Its institutional home is the Spiralweb Stewardship Association. This is Report 04 in Series III — Applied Protocols.

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1. What the Dashboard is

The Penguin Dashboard is a recurring conversation supported by a one-page record. It helps a group see whether its work is healthy enough to continue, strained enough to require correction, or exposed enough to require protection and pause.

Its purpose is not to turn a living place into a score. Its purpose is to make three forms of reality visible at the same time: what is happening to the place, what the work is costing the people involved, and whether the group can still decide and act responsibly together.

The Dashboard is a shared reading, not an automated verdict.

2. Why the three streams stay separate

Regenerative work becomes difficult to govern when unlike conditions are mixed into one general impression. A flourishing garden may conceal exhausted stewards. Warm relationships may conceal unclear authority. Excellent paperwork may conceal ecological decline.

Stream	What it protects	Monthly question
A — Land and Ecology	The living place and its ecological functions	What is changing in soil, water, habitat, species, and land condition?
B — People and Steward Viability	The people whose labour and care sustain the work	Can people continue without hidden sacrifice, exhaustion, or unmet basic needs?
C — Governance and Collaboration	Shared decisions, responsibility, participation, and repair	Are roles, decisions, conflict, and accountability clear enough to act together?

The separation is non-compensatory. Strong results in one stream cannot erase harm in another. This is especially important where the work is carried by people with little economic margin. Stream B prevents ecological ambition from being financed through invisible human cost.

3. How the colour reading works

Reading	Meaning	Responsible response
Green	The stream is sufficiently stable for the present work.	Continue, record what is supporting stability, and consider the next step without assuming approval.
Yellow	Strain, uncertainty, uneven participation, or emerging instability needs attention.	Name the concern, make a bounded correction, and gather further observation where needed.
Red	Ordinary continuation or expansion would expose people, place, or coordination to unacceptable risk.	Pause the affected action, protect against further harm, and convene a named review. Stabilising support may continue.

Non-compensation

A red stream remains red even when the other two are green. The Dashboard does not calculate an overall average. The purpose of the colour is to preserve what must not disappear from view.

Protection triggers

A circle may agree in advance that certain conditions require immediate caution: a safety issue, an unmet basic need, an unsustainable personal cost, a serious conflict, or a clear ecological breach. These triggers must be explicit, locally understood, and proportionate to the possible harm.

Judgment and dissent

The final colour is assigned by people who have reviewed the evidence and heard those carrying the consequences. Material disagreement is recorded rather than smoothed away. When relevant uncertainty cannot yet be resolved, the circle uses the more cautious reading.

4. Fifteen starter observations

The three streams are fixed. The observations are not. The following fifteen questions provide a manageable starting point that each circle adapts to its place, season, people, and work.

Code	Starter observation	Local calibration
A1	Ground cover, exposed soil, or another meaningful surface condition	Define what direction of change matters here.
A2	Water availability, retention, infiltration, or moisture duration	Adapt to rainfall, irrigation, soil, and season.
A3	Survival or establishment of selected plants or ecological structures	Agree the relevant cohort and a justified threshold.
A4	Condition of a locally important species, habitat, or ecological function	Name why it matters and who can interpret it.
A5	Circle judgment of the place's trajectory	Record the observations and uncertainty behind the judgment.
B1	Workload compared with what people actually agreed to carry	Use a humane rhythm, not surveillance.
B2	Self-reported energy, fatigue, or capacity	People name their own condition; the group does not overrule it.
B3	Basic and practical conditions required for participation	Define relevant needs such as food, rest, transport, safety, access, or care.
B4	Available people and role capacity compared with current work	Assess actual coverage rather than an ideal group size.
B5	Any person reporting an unsustainable personal cost	Treat a yes as a protection flag requiring response.
C1	Was the agreed reading or review actually held?	Record why it was missed and whether another rhythm applies.
C2	Were decisions and reasons recorded?	Use a form accessible to the people relying on it.
C3	Are roles, mandates, and responsibilities clear enough?	Notice ambiguity, overload, and informal concentrations of power.
C4	Are participation, onboarding, language, and access adequate?	Use only the dimensions relevant to the actual circle.
C5	Is there an unresolved conflict, breach, safety issue, or accountability gap?	Record severity, duration, affected people, and attempted response.

A circle may replace a proxy. It may not remove a stream or conceal direct concerns about harm, basic needs, personal cost, conflict, or responsibility.

5. The monthly snapshot

The snapshot is the shared surface of the practice. It should normally fit on one page. The evidence behind it may be much larger.

Stream	Colour and concise evidence	Uncertainty, dissent, or protection flag
A — Land and Ecology	Green / Yellow / Red What did we observe?	What remains uncertain or disputed?
B — People and Steward Viability	Green / Yellow / Red What did people report?	Is anyone carrying an unsustainable cost?
C — Governance and Collaboration	Green / Yellow / Red What is clear or unstable?	What conflict, ambiguity, or accountability issue remains?

Up to three decisions for the next period

1. What will be done?
2. Who holds responsibility?
3. When will the result be reviewed?

Evidence reference: link or name the notes, measurements, photographs, testimony, or documents supporting the reading.

6. Worked example: a school garden

A class establishes a garden with rainwater collection. Seedlings are surviving, the soil is increasingly covered, and the irrigation system works. Yet the teacher and three students carry nearly all the work, roles were never agreed, and the parent-association funds are not recorded.

Stream	Reading	Reason
A — Land and Ecology	Green	The garden is establishing and the water system functions.
B — People and Steward Viability	Yellow	Too much work is concentrated on too few people.
C — Governance and Collaboration	Yellow	Roles, decisions, and money are not yet clearly recorded.

The appropriate response is not more planting. The class first redistributes watering, appoints a rotating note-keeper, and records income and expenditure. The garden's visible success does not cancel the human and governance strain that currently sustains it.

7. From observation to decision

1. **Observation:** What happened, and how do we know?
2. **Interpretation:** What might the observations mean here?
3. **Working judgment:** Which colour best describes each stream?
4. **Decision:** What is the next responsible action?
5. **Later comparison:** What happened after the decision?

These movements must not be collapsed. An observation is not yet an interpretation. An interpretation is not yet a colour. A colour is not an automatic decision.

The one-page snapshot therefore points to an evidence trail. A PG Ledger or another locally usable record may hold measurements, photographs, testimonies, sources, disagreements, named responsibilities, and the later review.

8. Local calibration and scale

The three streams provide a common grammar. Their contents are place-bound. A dryland field, an urban wetland, a school garden, and a municipal programme cannot use identical ecological proxies or thresholds.

Wider frameworks such as 13×13 inquiry can help a circle ask what it has not yet noticed across ecological, bodily, institutional, technological, and economic dimensions. They are not hidden scoring systems behind the Dashboard and do not require a complete matrix every month.

Larger summaries may compare patterns, but they may not erase a local red condition. Scale should connect observations without removing their place, source, uncertainty, or consequence.

9. Moral Biology and Penguin Economics

Moral Biology begins from a practical proposition: biological, material, and relational conditions influence the range of cooperative, ethical, and long-horizon action available to people and institutions. The colours are governance descriptions, not clinical diagnoses.

Penguin Economics adds a principle of rotation. No person should carry the exposed edge indefinitely while others remain protected. Work, risk, attention, and rest must be redistributed visibly enough for the group to notice when a commons is being sustained through hidden sacrifice.

Together, the two concepts explain why Stream B is not a secondary welfare category. The viability of stewards is part of the ecological and institutional reality of the work.

10. Gold Before Bloom

Do not scale intake faster than a place and its people can hold the consequences. Before expansion, a major commitment, or a new flow of capital, the circle reads the current snapshot.

- **Red** means not yet for ordinary expansion or claims of success. It may mean now for protection, repair, or stabilising support.
- **Yellow** calls for correction and further observation.
- **Green** permits consideration of a next step. It does not approve that step automatically.

11. Funding and wider architecture

The Dashboard may inform funding, staffing, partnership, approval, a Correction Loop, or a longer field review. It does not automate these processes.

Detailed budgets, gate procedures, remedies, or release conditions belong in the relevant operational instrument. Report 04 specifies the interface they need: a visible account of current field condition, the evidence considered, the people who made the judgment, and the reason for the next action.

Repeated snapshots create a longitudinal record. A trend can invite inquiry into recurring strain or successful repair, but a sequence of colours never replaces the underlying observations and human interpretation.

12. AI boundary and human responsibility

AI may organise observations, compare records, identify missing information, translate drafts, and prepare summaries. It may not determine field truth, assign Dashboard colours, approve funding, or replace the circle's reading.

Every consequential decision must remain attributable to named people who can be questioned, corrected, and held responsible. The fuller repair and accountability architecture is described in Report 02 — The Correction Loop.

Conclusion

The Penguin Dashboard is intentionally small: three separate streams, fifteen locally calibrated observation slots, three colour judgments, an evidence trail, and a limited set of next actions.

Its discipline lies in what it refuses to do. It does not average away harm, substitute universal proxies for local knowledge, turn a one-page interface into proof, automate consequential decisions, or remove responsibility from named people.

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Glossary

Dashboard

The recurring shared reading and record described in this report.

Non-compensation

A green stream cannot cancel a red condition elsewhere.

Protection trigger

A locally agreed condition requiring minimum caution, protection, or pause.

Local calibration

Documented adaptation of observations and thresholds to a specific place and circle.

Evidence trail

The sources, observations, testimony, uncertainty, and decisions behind the snapshot.

PG Ledger

A place-bound record connecting evidence, interpretation, responsibility, and later review.

Moral Biology

The proposition that material and biological conditions shape ethical and cooperative capacity.

Penguin Economics

The visible rotation of exposure, burden, work, and care.

Gold Before Bloom

The discipline of establishing sufficient substrate before scaling intake or expectation.

Responsibility anchor

The requirement that consequential judgment remains attributable to named humans.

